

No. 10

Memo on discussions by the Chairman of the SPD, Brandt, with the French President, Mitterrand

25 September 1981¹

AdsD, WBA, A 9, 35.

Published in: Berliner Ausgabe, vol. 9

English translation: Dwight E. Langston

[The discussions centred on issues of security policy.]

François Mitterrand stated that by and large there is now, in the year 1981, a strategic balance. By 1985 there will be Soviet superiority.² After that, by about the year 1992, he foresees superiority by the United States.

His thinking also takes into account strategically effective aircraft.

France could already produce the neutron bomb today but will, in all probability, not do this. The neutron bomb presupposes a strategy of gradual response, and this strategy is not commensurate with the capabilities of French nuclear forces.³ The agreement, played up by the Soviet ambassador in Paris after discussions with him, to the effect that a balance must prevail in Europe, was not really consistent with the course of the discussions and his own convictions. Balance must exist worldwide and not only in Europe. Besides, France's nuclear forces are only a little bit greater than what is absolutely necessary as a deterrent, so that France cannot accept the inclusion of these forces in negotiations.⁴

He is in favour of negotiations. The USA must not aspire to superiority.

He is against moratoriums because 150 SS 20s are sufficient to destroy everything.⁵ He sees no sense in the dismantling of overkill capacities.

It is clear to him that the introduction of Pershing would change the strategic situation fundamentally (de nature) and “il serait bon, si cela ne se produirait pas.” (“it would be good if that would not come to pass.”)⁶

His statements for the *Stern* interview were reported in abbreviated form. He is in agreement with the basis of the NATO Resolution.⁷

In his response, Willy Brandt summarised the German understanding of the NATO Resolution. For a while we had to fear that the USA regarded this differently.

Besides, the East's conventional superiority has already existed for a long time. Of course, it is exaggerated to some extent. If the USA wanted to match it conventionally, it would have to reinstitute the military draft.

Willy Brandt commented on the particular German situation which could result from the stationing of SS 20s – whose exact quality, incidentally, is difficult to evaluate⁸ – and the introduction of Pershing and Cruise missiles as well as whatever military reaction by the Soviet Union might be anticipated.⁹ He suggested that François Mitterrand discuss the Euro-strategic and global balance with the German Chancellor at their upcoming talks.¹⁰

He expressed understanding for the French position but referred, at the same time, to the issue of the legitimizing of a Soviet balance to the French forces and of Soviet concerns about security policy vis-à-vis China.

In conclusion, Willy Brandt commented on the concerns of the young generation in the Federal Republic and their consequences for the SPD.

François Mitterrand considers it legitimate to take into account a Soviet counterbalance to French forces.

Besides, he has to deal with an elemental contradiction whose solution he does not yet see: the contradiction between national

determination of French atomic forces and the obligations of solidarity which arise from membership in the Atlantic Alliance. The question as to when French security interest are endangered to the core cannot be answered precisely.

He can indeed understand Adenauer's position, mentioned by Willy Brandt, that no missiles which could threaten the Soviet Union must be stationed in the Federal Republic of Germany.¹¹ For that reason, he hopes that the Pershing will not have to be stationed. He also understands the Soviet Union's apprehensions. In essence, relative strengths are circumstances of the times ("rapport de forces = rapport de temps"). We must attempt through negotiations to eliminate the SS 20s, and that is what he will make even clearer in public. He does not want Germany to become a powder keg. In addition, he wishes to emphasize that he does not use the term "neutralism" with reference to developments in Germany.¹²

<Thomas] Mirow>¹³

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- 1 This template copy is a copy of Thomas Mirow's memo, dated 28 September 1981. On top of the page is noted: "Ø H[ans]-J[ürgen] W[ischnewski] personal/confidential". At the start of the text Mirow noted: "Re.: Discussion Willy Brandt with the French President François Mitterrand on 25 September 1981 in the Elysée (also present: Thomas Mirow; interpreter)".
 - 2 Cf. *Risse-Kappen* 1988, p. 29 ff.
 - 3 The French nuclear forces, the *Force de dissuasion*, was based on a doctrine of deterrence, which should prevent a nuclear endangering of French territory by the threat of a heavy retaliatory strike. The French nuclear potential comprised 98 warheads and consisted of 18 (obsolete) intercontinental ballistic missile, deployed on the Plateau d'Albion, and a flotilla of nuclear submarines. Under Mitterrand the 7th nuclear submarine was put into service and the lavish modernization of the intercontinental ballistic missiles was arranged. On French the neutron weapon cf. AdG 51 (1980), p. 24798.
 - 4 For Mitterrand – contrary to Brandt and large parts of SPD – the non-inclusion of the French nuclear potential in the INF-negotiations in Geneva was a *conditio sine qua non*.
 - 5 Cf. no. 65, note 15.
 - 6 "It would be good if that would not come to pass."
 - 7 Cf. Interview Mitterrand, in: *Stern*, No. 29 of 29 July 1981, p. 80-84. Cf. No. 50, Note 10.
 - 8 Cf. Introduction.
 - 9 Cf. No. 65, Note 9.
 - 10 On 7-9 October 1981 Schmidt paid an informal visit to Mitterrand in his country house in Latche. Cf. EA 36 (1981) 21, p. 211.
 - 11 Cf. No. 66.

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- 12 Mitterrand alludes to the formation of a strong anti-missiles movement in the Federal Republic of Germany, which challenged not only the validity of the NATO-doctrine of nuclear deterrence, but also increasingly the membership of the Federal Republic to the Western alliance. Cf. Introduction and Berliner Ausgabe, vol. 5.
- 13 Handwritten signature.